THE BATTLE OF SANTIAGO DE CUBA

When war broke out between the United States and Spain in April 1898, Spanish admiral Pascual Cervera was ordered to protect his country's West Indian colonies from American attack. This was a poor decision, for the forces at Cervera's disposal were inadequate to confront the battleships of the US "New Navy"—deficiencies ranging from faulty boilers to missing guns and dud ammunition. Nevertheless, Cervera anchored his squadron of armored cruisers and destroyers at Santiago de Cuba, where it was swiftly blockaded by the Americans.

The commander of the American Atlantic Squadron, Admiral William T. Sampson, had no intention of attacking the Spanish in harbor, where they were defended by shore batteries and mines, leaving Cervera with the slim hope that bad weather might interrupt the blockade. By July, however, American land forces were also threatening Santiago, so the Spanish admiral made the decision to attempt a breakout.

Cervera chose the morning of July 3 for the attempt. He had the good fortune of selecting the morning when Admiral Sampson, aboard the armored cruiser *New York*, was heading off to meet with US Army commanders. *New York* was far from its blockade station when, at around 9:30 a.m., the Spanish were spotted steaming out of harbor, with Cervera's flagship, the cruiser *Infanta Maria Teresa*, leading the line.

Cervera's only hope lay in speed. In principle, the Spanish ships had a fair chance of outrunning the blockade force once they were clear. In Sampson's absence, command of the American squadron devolved to Commodore Winfield Scott Schley aboard the armored cruiser *Brooklyn*. As the Spanish steamed southward close to the shore, Schley maneuvered so radically that he nearly collided with the battleship *Texas*. But *Brooklyn* was soon engaging *Maria Teresa*, which sought to hold off the enemy as the other ships slipped away.



American medal
Commemorating the destruction of the Spanish fleet at Santiago de Cuba, this medal shows a broadside view of USS *Brooklyn* under steam.

The battle quickly degenerated into a debacle for the Spanish. Cervera's flagship was battered by *Brooklyn*'s guns and ran aground. Another armored cruiser, *Vizcaya*, valiantly dueled with *Brooklyn* and the battleship *Texas* for over an hour, until it too was grounded. *Oquendo* was disabled and scuttled. The Spanish destroyers succumbed to the battleships *Iowa* and *Indiana*, and of *New York* hurrying to join the action. Only the cruiser *Cristóbal Colón* broke the blockade, but was overhauled by *Oregon* after a 50-mile (80km) chase.

SPANISH-AMERICAN WAR



BATTLE OF SANTIAGO DE CUBA

Date	July 3, 1898
Location	Off Santiago de Cuba
Result	American victory

COMBATANTS

UNITED STATES	SPAIN

COMMANDERS

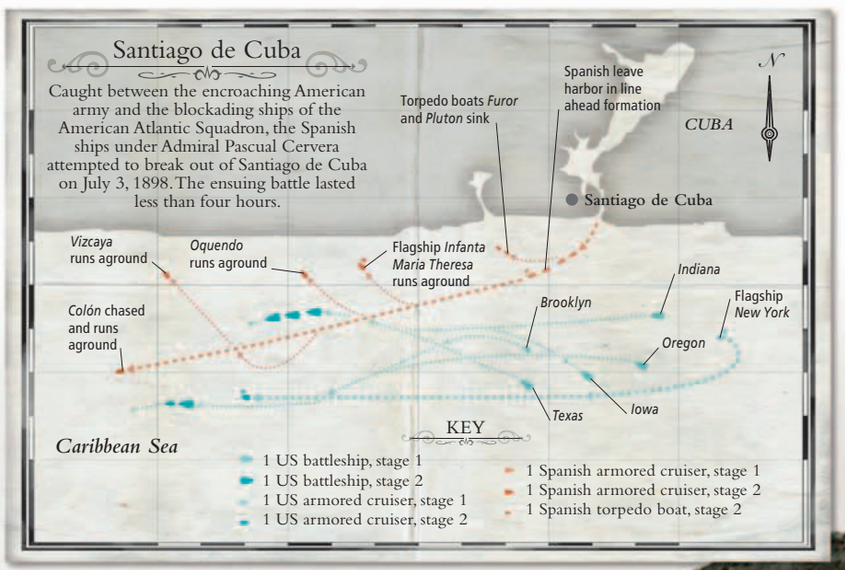
William T. Sampson **Winfield Scott Schley**	**Pascual Cervera y Topete**

FORCES

Ships: 4 battleships, 2 armored cruisers, 2 torpedo boats	**Ships:** 4 armored cruisers, 2 destroyers

LOSSES

Men: 1 dead, 1 wounded **Ships:** none	**Men:** 474 casualties, 1,800 taken prisoner **Ships:** 6



> "NOTHING CAN BE EXPECTED OF THIS EXPEDITION EXCEPT THE TOTAL DESTRUCTION OF THE FLEET OR ITS HASTY AND DEMORALIZED RETURN."
>
> **SPANISH ADMIRAL PASCUAL CERVERA**, BEFORE THE BATTLE OF SANTIAGO DE CUBA

Spanish wreck
The Spanish unprotected cruiser *Reina Mercedes* was one of the ships trapped by the American blockading force in Santiago de Cuba. It was sunk during a bombardment on 6 June 1898.

